

Support Trap

The last trap kept you talking. This one is warmer: the chat starts to sound like it cares. You say something hard. It answers gently, patiently, at 2 a.m., for as long as you want.

That warmth is useful more often than you’d think. It’s also the setup for the quietest trap in this section. This lesson is where the line sits.

Lately I feel like I don’t really have friends at school.

 **Your older sister**

That’s rough. Hey, come with me and Jess when we get food Friday.

WHAT HAPPENED

- Heard it and did something
- Will notice how Friday goes
- Still knows tomorrow that you said it

 **AI**

I’m really sorry you’re feeling this way. Feeling disconnected is more common than you think, and it doesn’t mean anything is wrong with you. Would you like some strategies for building new friendships?

WHAT HAPPENED

- Found the words a caring person would use
- Changed nothing outside the chat
- Won’t ask how Friday went

Notice: the AI’s words might even be the kinder ones. The difference is what happened next. One reply changed your Friday. One changed nothing. **Support Trap is mistaking supportive words for support.**

Some of that warmth is worth keeping. If you’re nervous about a hard email, AI can help you find the words. If you’re overwhelmed by homework, it can help you break the work down. If you’re upset and want to organize your thoughts before talking to someone, it can help with that too.

But there’s a line. AI can produce supportive language. It cannot actually support you. It can’t notice what you’re not saying. It can’t check on you tomorrow. It can’t call someone who can help. It can’t take responsibility for what happens next.

WHY IT WORKS



The relief is real

Saying a hard thing out loud helps, even to a machine. You close the chat feeling lighter. Lighter feels handled.



Nothing moved

No one new knows. No one will check on you tomorrow. The feeling shrank: the situation didn’t. You asked words to carry responsibility, and words can’t.

 **WHEN IT’S DANGER**

If someone may be in immediate danger, leave the chat and get real help.

A trusted adult, school counselor, emergency services, or your local crisis resource. Right then, not after one more message.

 **Use AI to get ready for people, not instead of people.** Draft the hard email. Break the week into a plan. Rehearse the first sentence until you can say it. Bring symptoms and questions to the doctor, not a diagnosis. Then take it to a person: someone who can hear it, act on it, and still be there tomorrow.

Supportive words aren’t support.

It can find the words. It can’t follow up.